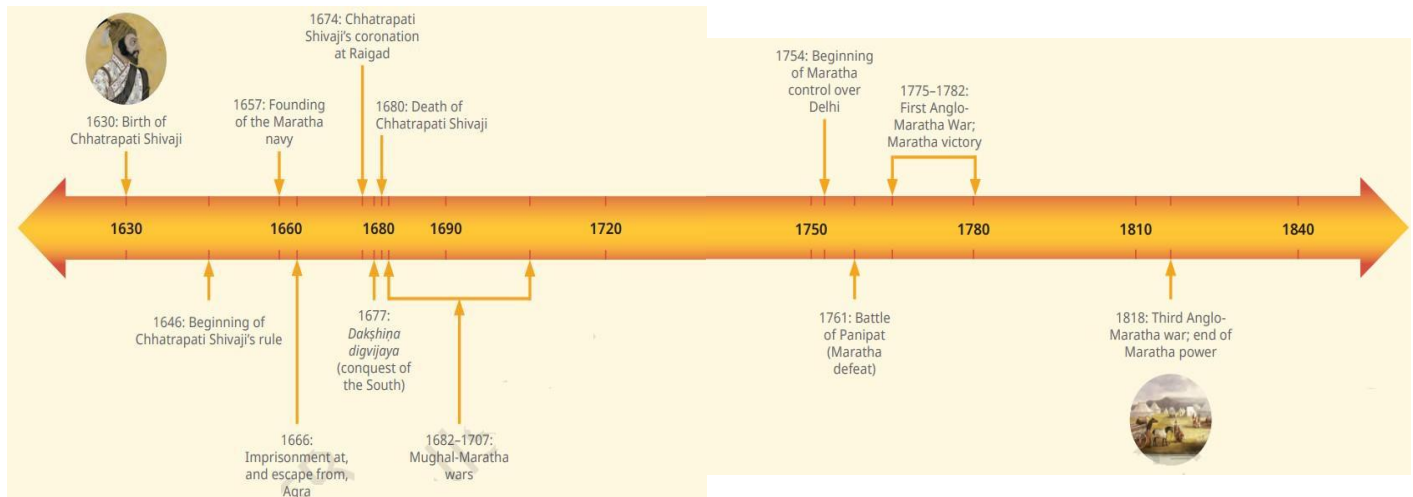


Chapter – 3: The Rise of the Marathas

Among the merchants, the hat-wearers like the Portuguese, the English, the Dutch, the French and the Danes also conduct trade. But they are not like other merchants.... They are fully intent on entering this land, increasing their territory and propagating their religion. They are obstinate people, and Navy and gunpowder are their chief weapons. Their traffic should be controlled, and they shouldn't be allowed to build strong buildings. — Ramachandrapant Amatya, Ādnyāpatra (1715)



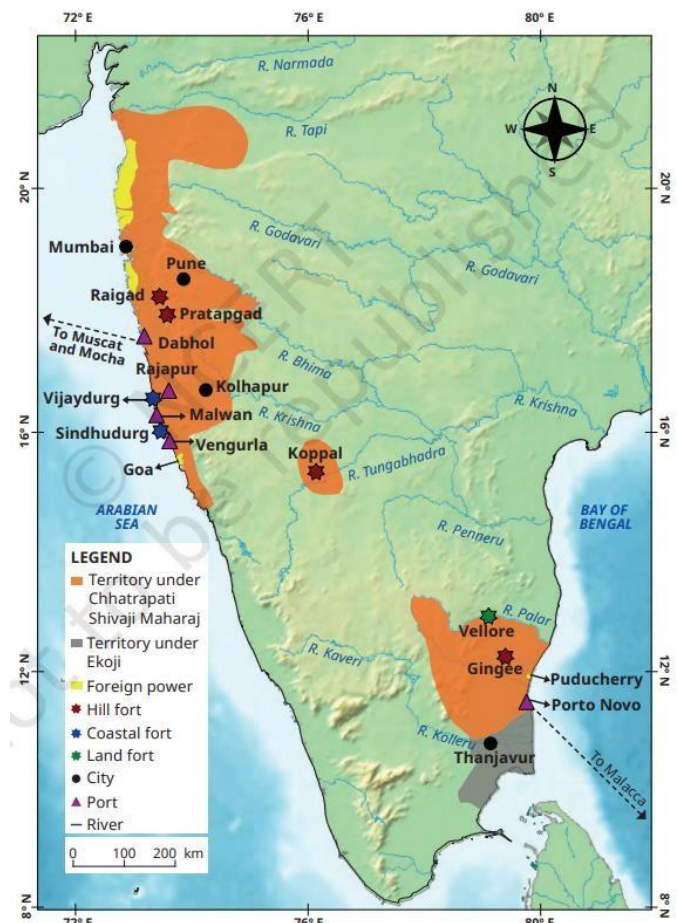
Who are the Marathas?

- Marathas – grp. – people – native – Deccan plateau – specific – present-day Maharashtra
- Identified – language – Marathi – rich, continuous – **literary history** – 12th cent.
- This chapter – see them – rise – powerful political entity – alter course – India's history
- 13th cent. – most Maharashtra – rulers – Yadava dynasty – Devagiri (present – Daulatabad) – capital
- Early 14th cent. – Yadava dynasty – overcome by – Khilji Sultanate, Delhi
- Amidst political changes – cultural traditions continued – related to Bhakti – devotion to divine
- 7th-17th cent. – spiritual upliftment – saints, seekers – several parts – prefer – path – Bhakti, external ritualism
- These saints – diverse sections – society – devotional songs, poetry – languages – masses – allowed msg. – travel – far
- Maharashtra – many saints – Dnyaneshwar, Namdev, Tukaram, Ramdas – more popular – this time
- Help – translate – imp. texts – Upanishads, Bhagavat Gita – Marathi – their philosophy – accessible – people
- Some – focused – social org., political awareness – similar – Sikh gurus
- Result – society – solid cultural foundation – later helped – Marathas – organise – political power
- 17th cent. – Maratha chief – early attempts – establish sovereignty – unsuccessful – until – Chhatrapati Shivaji – power – united Marathas

Foundation of Maratha Power and the Rise of Chhatrapati Shivaji

- 1630 – Shivaji – born – Bhonsle clan – Shahji, Jijabai
- At time – Shahji – serve – Deccan Sultanate – away from home
- His **jagir** – Pune – Shivaji grew up – watchful eyes Jijabai, trusted officials – values, education
- This time – Pune region – deeply affected – const. infighting – Deccan sultans – Marathas served – hardship – common people

- Just 16 – Shivaji – military campaign – consolidating hold – Pune region – capture – neglected, unoccupied forts – strengthen defenses
- His vision – sovereign kingdom – Swarajya – grew over yrs. – extend – political, economic, cultural aspects – explore – this chapter
- Shivaji's kingdom – expanded – India's west coast – secure resources – coastal regions – felt need – establish navy
- Truly revolutionary step – that time
- Comparison – Bijapur Sultanate (Adil Shahi dynasty) – merchant ships – BUT – no full-time naval force
- Mughal empire – use of navy – very limited
- Thus – Maratha navy – born – exploits – legendary
- Protect people – powerful enemies – Shivaji – recourse – tactic – guerilla warfare – small grps. – focused way – speed, surprise, knowledge – terrain – defeat – bigger enemies
- His success – invited wrath – Bijapur Sultanate – sent gen. Afzal Khan – confront him
- Shivaji, associates – convinced Afzal Khan – one-on-one meeting – foot – Pratapgad fort – thick forests
- Shivaji – killed Afzal – Marathas – hidden in mountains – routed Khan's army – guerrilla attacks
- Soon – Mughal nobleman – Shaista Khan – invaded Shivaji's territory – 3 yrs.
- Only few soldiers – Shivaji raided Khan's camp – Khan – barely escaped – lose fingers – left Maharashtra – this raid – resembles – modern **surgical strikes**
- Retaliatory action – Shivaji – sacked Surat – wealthy port city – Mughal empire
- There – obt. – enormous treasure – 1 crore rupees – extremely large sum – that time
- BUT – very careful – never attack – religious places – spared – Mohandas Parekh – charitable man
- Sacked Surat again – few yrs. later
- These events – very famous – appeared – London Gazette – English newspaper – that time – conveyed – Shivaji – wrote – all European diplomatic agents – Surat – demand – immediate presents – fail that – city ruined
- Sacking – Surat – great insult – might, prestige – Mughal empire
- Aurangzeb – sent Jai Singh – Rajput General – defeat Shivaji
- Against him – Shivaji – concede defeat – Purandar fort (Pune) – enter treaty
- Give up – sizable part – kingdom – son Sambhaji – enter Mughal service
- Shivaji – persuaded by – Jai Singh – visit Mughal court – Agra – stand before – Aurangzeb, Mughal general – defeated earlier
- This insult – Shivaji – stormed out – put under – house arrest
- Escape this – Shivaji – devised strategy – distribute gifts – holy men, Mughal generals – gifts – fruits, sweets – big baskets
- Guards – checked them – BUT – stopped soon – expecting that – Shivaji, son Sambhaji – hid in baskets – made escape
- Aurangzeb – couldn't capture – Shivaji again



- Few yrs. later – Shivaji – coronated – full Vedic rites – string mountain fortress – Raigad
- Formal title – Shri Raja Shiva Chhatrapati – other past rulers – own era – *Rajyabhisheka shaka*
- After this – Shivaji conquest – South – *Dakshina-digvijaya* – incl. – imp., ill-defended region – present-day – Tamil Nadu, Karnataka
- Southern extension – later – Marathas – strategic depth – Mughal invasion
- Fever – claimed Shivaji's life – 50 yr. old
- Master strategist – true visionary – his lifetime – exploits – legendary – India, beyond
- Europeans – compared him – great gen. – Alexander – Bundela Prince Chhatrasal – so inspired – Shivaji's struggle – create independent kingdom – Bundelkhand
- Famous Hindi poet – Bhushan – came to Maharashtra – meet Shivaji – composed poems – his praise – still famous

The Marathas after Chhatrapati Shivaji

- Shivaji – 2 sons – Sambhaji, Rajaram – after Shivaji's death – Sambhaji – next Chhatrapati
- Marathas – only obstacle – total Mughal control – Deccan
- Aurangzeb – invaded Deccan – conquered – Bijapur (Adil Shahi), Golconda (Qutb Shahi) Sultanates
- Captured Sambhaji – brutal torture – executed him – captured Raigad – Maratha capital
- Next Chhatrapati – Rajaram – fled to Gingee – Mughal-Maratha conflict – spread – south India
- Marathas – defended fortresses – upper hand – Mughals – battles, skirmishes
- Aurangzeb – unable – leave Deccan – died – without success – subdue Marathas – strong contender – Mughals
- No longer – defensive – Marathas – led by – Tarabai – Rajaram's queen – large-scale inroads – Mughal territories – conquer – large parts – India
- Rapid expansion – Marathas – structural transformation
- Centralized state – Shivaji's time – gave way – decentralized structure – centered – Chhatrapati – BUT – chiefs – more power
- Peshwa – Persian – prime minister – great influence – even over Chhatrapati
- Peshwa Bajirao I – son Nana Saheb Peshwa – instrumental – pan-India expansion – Marathas
- Marathas – large parts – India – under control – ruled well
- BUT – regional chiefs – more power, autonomy – result – indiscipline, abuse – contrast – Shivaji's values
- Ex. – Marathas – 10-yr campaign – Bengal – much cruelty, devastation – common people
- Northward expansion – Marathas – brief control – areas – Lahore, Attock, Peshawar
- Fought – Afghans – disastrous defeat – Panipat – 1761 – quick recovery – Peshwa Madhavrao I
- Leadership – Mahadji Shinde (Mahadji Scindia) – recapture Delhi – 1771 – under control – British took over – 3 decades later
- Later half – 18th cent. – chief rivals – British – Marathas – 3 Anglo-Maratha wars – fought – 1775-1818
- Marathas – increased internal disunity – superior org., tech. abilities – British – succeeded – ending – Maratha power
- Effect – British – took over – more India – from Marathas than other powers

Maratha Administration

Civilian administration

- Shivaji – centralized administration – his kingdom

- Abolished – hereditary posts, land assignments – paid salary – every govt. official – state treasury
- Many officials – periodic transfers – ensuring – not enough power – dictate terms – king
- Shivaji – pensions – widows – soldiers – died in battles – offering military posts – their sons – demonstrate care – soldiers, families
- Shivaji – *ashta pradhana mandala* – council – 8 ministers – assist him – administration
- Marathas – taxes – *chauth* (25%) – *sardeshmukhi* (additional 10%) – provinces – not under them – directly – Deccan, north India
- In return – Marathas – protected provinces – not intervention – internal administration
- Mughals – approved arrangement – various treaties – over time – some provinces – part – Maratha empire



Military administration

- Maratha armed forces – 3 parts – infantry, cavalry, navy
- Cavalry – 2 types – *bargirs* – horses, equipment – paid by state – *shiledars* – horses, equipment – paid by themselves
- 18th cent. – Marathas – noticed – superiority – European style – troops, artillery – tried – raise, recruit – such troops
- Mahadji Shinde – large army – European style
- Swords, lances – preferred weapons – Marathas – BUT – used guns – sizable numbers
- Rockets – military campaigns – Shivaji's time – 1770 – metal tube rockets – also used
- Saw earlier – forts – mainstay – Maratha power
- Shivaji – controlled, built – considerable no. – forts – essential – strategic control – imp. routes – shelter army – engaging – guerrilla warfare
- Ramachandrapant Amatya – finance minister – Shivaji – his work – *Adnyapatra* – royal addict –
 - Forts – core – state – their absence – land – devastated – invasion
 - Former kings – secured country – building forts
 - This kingdom – created – late great master – forts alone
 - Great enemy – Aurangzeb invaded – conquered great empires – Bijapur, Bhaganagar
 - BUT – due to forts – state – survived – decades of onslaught

Maritime supremacy

- We saw – Shivaji – navy – secure – west coast
- 18th cent. – Kanhoji Angre – guided Marathas – victory – naval battles – clever use – geography, battle tactics – even – European ships – more tech. advanced
- That time – Europeans – main strength – navies
- Forced Indians – purchase – naval trade passes – some price – without pass – ship – confiscated
- Marathas – challenged practice – demanded passes – Europeans – showed frustration – label Kanhoji – pirate

Judicial system

- Marathas – efficient judicial sys. – remarkable – moderation – capital punishment (death penalty)
- Panchayat* – not today's panchayat – local gathering – officials, prominent men – main body – delivered justice
- Appeal – Maratha chief – unsatisfactory verdict

- Various towns – Pune, Indore – *kotwal* (police) – also deployed – ensure – law, order – within city

Trade networks

- Shivaji – encouraged trade – active participation – maritime foreign trade
- He, his officials – own ships – regularly sent – ports – Mocha, Yemen – Muscat, Oman – Malacca, Malaysia
- Some ships – carry cargo – gold, textiles
- Roads – constructed, maintained – Odisha – 18th cent. – network – ferries – maintained – riverine transport
- Bridges – built – rivers, small streams

Cultural Revival

- Marathas – contribute – India's cultural developments
- Shivaji's vision – Swarajya – evident – his seal – Sanskrit inscription – notable departure – prevalent Persian seal –
 - This seal – Shivaji – son of Shahji – waxing – new moon – revered by world – reigns for welfare
- Shivaji – commissioned treatise – *Rajya-Vyavahara-Kosha* – aim – promote – Marathi lang. – provided – Sanskrit equivalent – prevalent Persian words – diplomatic exchanges – result – percentage – foreign loanwords – Maratha diplomacy – decreased
- Shivaji – devout Hindu – respected other religions – upholding own
- Saffron-colour flag – adopted – all Marathas
- Rebuilt – desecrated temples – promote – Sanskrit, Marathi literature – religious institution – traditional arts
- Contribute most – revival – ancient Indian culture, values – giving people – demonstration – mighty kingdoms, empires – defeated – BUT – Marathas – maintain, expand, administer – empire – their own
- **The mighty Maratha women**
 - **Tarabai** – fearless Maratha warrior queen – ruled – early 18th cent. – after death – husband – Rajaram
 - Realizing – presence – Aurangzeb, Mughal army – Deccan, north India – unprotected – organized – large Maratha armies – sent them – invade Mughal territories – north
 - Architect – northward Maratha expansion
 - Her sense – military strategy – her tenacity – outsmarted Mughal empire – preserved independence – critical period
 - **Ahilyabai Holkar** – scion – Holkar dynasty – chief families – instrumental – Maratha expansion – north India
 - 18th cent. – this dynasty – ruled kingdom – considerable extent – central India – present-day Indore
 - Losing son, husband – governed state – 30 yrs. – administer wisely – caring – common people
 - Ahilyabai – devout person – built, restored – temples, ghats, wells, roads – all India – Kedarnath, North to Rameswaram, South
 - Rebuilt – Kashi Vishwanath temple – Varanasi – destroyed by Aurangzeb – Somnath temple – Gujarat – destroyed by Mahmud of Ghazni
 - Ahilyabai Holkar – also credited – Maheshwar weaving industry – Madhya Pradesh – revitalize – traditional handloom – thrive today
- Shivaji's ex. – continue – inspire – successors
- Ex. – Bhonsles, Nagpur – enthusiastic supporters – local culture, tradition

- Worship – deity – Jagannath, Puri – revived – Maratha support
- BUT – most impressive contribution – few remarkable Maratha women

In focus: Thanjavur

- Turn southward – witness – another ex. – cultural contribution
- Ekoji – half-brother – Shivaji – conquer Thanjavur region – late 17th cent. – beginning – Maratha rule – this area
- Thanjavur Marathas – help create – syncretic culture – rich, full – innovation
- Great patrons – arts – many rulers – themselves – poets, dramatists
- All Thanjavur Marathas – contribution – Serfoji II – most notable
- Well-versed – Indian, European lang. – wrote Marathi play – *Devendra Kuravanji* – describes – world geography – detail – known at time
- Serfoji – patronized – talented musicians – his time – modern Carnatic music – took shape – also – classical dance form – Bharatanatyam
- Serfoji – interested – medicine – established – Dhanwantari Mahal – centre of medicine – free treatment – both – Indian, Western medicine
- Also started – printing press – 1st such ex. – India – native ruler
- History – Bhonsle family – inscribed – walls – Brihadishwara temple – Thanjavur – largest single inscriptions – India
- Cultural env. – Thanjavur – multilingual – mix – many influences
- Local Tamil culture – Telugu culture (foreign rulers) – Marathi culture (current rulers) – interacted – each other

The Maratha legacy

- Maratha rule – challenged Mughal dominance – established – largest Indian empire – before – British took over
- Set up – new way – governing – efficient administration – also revived – local Hindu traditions – no religious discrimination
- Brave fight – oppressive rule, foreign power – driven by – fiery ideal – Swarajya
- Later – inspired many Indians – believe – govern themselves – planting early seeds – India's freedom movement